

Caribbean Cruise Packing Cheat Sheet

Warm days, cool evenings, formal nights, and the bag-size math — one page, by month.

THE CORE LIST (7-NIGHT CARIBBEAN SAILING)

Lightweight tops	5–7
Shorts / skirts	2–3
Underwear & socks	5–7 pairs
Swimsuits + cover-up	2 + 1 cover-up
Dinner / formal outfit	1–2
Light layer	1 — ship AC + cool Dec–Feb evenings
Sandals (worn) + water shoes	1 pair water shoes packed
Reef-safe sunscreen SPF 50+	essential — bring your own; onboard prices are steep
Daypack + power bank	1 each, for shore days

CARIBBEAN WEATHER BY MONTH (DAY HIGHS)

December	~75–85°F · dry season begins · holiday sailings
January	~75–82°F · one of the driest · cooler evenings · best value
February	low–mid 80s°F · warm & calm · peak season
March	low–mid 80s°F · warm water · spring-break crowds

FORMAL & HOLIDAY NIGHTS

- 1–2 dressier evenings per 7-night sailing; many lines are now "smart casual" — check yours before packing a suit.
- December holiday sailings and New Year's galas lean dressier; a Valentine's cruise (February) can too.
- Dedicated dress shoes are the single item that most often tips people into a checked bag.

SHORE DAYS & SUN

- Some islands restrict sunscreens with reef-harming ingredients — Aruba restricts oxybenzone, Bonaire oxybenzone + octinoxate — so a mineral sunscreen is a simple choice; check your itinerary. Bring your own; onboard prices are steep.
- Water shoes for coral or rocky beach entries; a light daypack for water, sunscreen, and a layer.
- Back-at-ship rule: whatever you carry off the ship, you carry all day — pack the daypack light.

THE BAG-SIZE MATH

- Light packers: 24–30L · Most Caribbean cruises: 30–40L · Multiple outfits or gear: 40L+.
- Warm weather makes this the easiest cruise to do carry-on-only (30–40L) — but many cruisers reasonably check a bag.

Build your personalized item-by-item list free at packfitter.com/packing-list-generator.html

Weather figures are typical ranges, verified September 2026. Conditions vary — always check your week's forecast before sailing.